



JENNIFER ROGERS, Will Rogers' great-granddaughter, takes in the ruins of the humorist's ranch house in Pacific Palisades.

Will Rogers' home: What now?

At his century-old Pacific Palisades ranch house, fans of the famed cowboy-humorist tried to preserve his legacy. Then everything burned.

By Hailey Branson-Potts

The sun had just set on the West Coast on Jan. 7 when Jennifer Rogers' phone pinged in Oklahoma. What played on her screen was a 14-second video message: A dark, smoky sky. A friend speaking, his voice steady and sad, as he pointed toward the orange glow of the fast-encroaching Palisades fire. "OK, Jenn, it's in the park," he said. "Without a doubt."

The park — named after Rogers' great-grandfather — was Will Rogers Historic State Park in Pacific Palisades. A two-story wooden ranch house, the last place the cowboy-humorist had called home, stood there.

After watching the video, Jennifer Rogers, who lives near her



AL SEIB Los Angeles Times

IN A 1927 letter to his architect, Rogers said he wanted the cream-colored house to be a simple, box-like structure.

great-grandfather's grave site in Claremore, Okla., "just put my phone on silent and sat and cried."

The fire destroyed Will Rogers' century-old house, which is listed on the National Register of Historic Places. And it incinerated his white-and-green stable with its stately central rotunda.

In the surrounding park — 186 wooded acres cut with ocean-view hiking and equestrian trails — more than 200 trees planted in the 1920s and '30s at Rogers' behest were so badly charred they soon will be removed, according to California State Parks officials.

Four months after the fire, a portion of the still-closed park is being used as a processing site for [See Rogers, A9]

State gained people again in 2024

California saw its population grow for second straight year after an exodus during pandemic emergency.

By TERRY CASTLEMAN

California's population increased for the second consecutive year, with much of the growth coming to the state's biggest cities, according to new data from the state Department of Finance.

The latest numbers for calendar year 2024 confirm the end of the so-called California exodus that saw the Golden State's population shrink for the first time in decades.

Seven of the state's 10 largest cities recorded population growth as they bounced back from the shrinking seen earlier in the pandemic, which hit hardest in most of the state's urban centers.

By the end of 2024, the state's population nearly eclipsed its pre-pandemic peak, but was still about 9,000 people short of the high-water mark from April 2020, reflecting slow growth in the years since then.

From April 2020 to January 2022, the state lost about 360,000 residents, according to the data released by the Department of Finance on Thursday. California added about 108,000 people in 2024 after adding nearly 200,000 in 2023. If growth continues, [See Population, A8]

3 quit in protest of deputy's plea deal

Prosecutors resign after offer by new U.S. attorney in Lancaster excessive force case.

By BRITTNY MEJIA, JAMES QUEALLY AND KERI BLAKINGER

Several federal prosecutors — including the chief of the Public Corruption and Civil Rights Section — have submitted their resignations after a plea deal offered by the new U.S. attorney in Los Angeles to a sheriff's deputy who had already been found guilty of using excessive force.

Two sources confirmed to The Times that Assistant U.S. Attys. Eli A. Alcaraz, Brian R. Faerstein and section chief Cassie Palmer resigned from the office over a "post-trial" plea agreement filed Thursday in the case of Trevor Kirk, an L.A. County sheriff's deputy who was convicted of a felony for assaulting and pepper-spraying a woman outside a Lancaster supermarket.

Reached Saturday afternoon, Faerstein said he had no comment. None of the other prosecutors said to have resigned responded to [See Prosecutors, A8]

Disruptive scene for screenwriters

Recent graduates struggle to break into film, TV as industry shrinks

By MALIA MENDEZ

Since the start of the year, Brandy Hernandez has applied to nearly 200 entertainment jobs.

The 22-year-old film school graduate, who works as a receptionist at the Ross Stores buying office in downtown Los Angeles, said that for most of those applications, she never heard back — not even a rejection. When

she did land follow-up interviews, she was almost always ghosted afterward.

"I knew that I wouldn't be a famous screenwriter or anything straight out of college," said Hernandez, who graduated from the USC School of Cinematic Arts in 2024. But she thought she'd at least be qualified for an entry-level film industry job.

"It shouldn't be this hard," she kept thinking. [See Screenwriter, A12]



ROBERT HANASHIRO For The Times

YOUNG screenwriters like Brandy Hernandez, left, Peter Gerard and Lore Olivera face a tough market as strikes and the rise of streaming have taken a toll.

NPR stations Trump aims to cut have been disaster lifelines

By JOHN RABY AND JAMIE STENGLE

CHARLESTON, W.Va. — After Hurricane Helene devastated Asheville, N.C., the sound coming from open car windows as residents gathered on a street at the top of a ridge trying to get cell serv-

ice in the fall was Blue Ridge Public Radio.

And as they stood in line for water or food, the latest news they'd heard on the station was a frequent topic of conversation.

"The public radio station was alerting people what was going on," said Lisa Savage, who volunteered at an

area church after the hurricane.

Now public radio stations are being targeted for cuts by President Trump. Last week, he signed an executive order aimed at slashing public subsidies to National Public Radio and the Public Broadcasting Service, alleging [See Public radio, A8]

Trump unsure on due process rights

President says he does not know if U.S. citizens and noncitizens alike deserve that guarantee. **NATION, A5**

Bomb plot foiled at Gaga concert

Brazilian police arrest pair in an alleged plan to target LGBTQ+ fans in Rio. **WORLD, A4**

Weather

Low clouds may clear. L.A. Basin: 68/57. **B5**

For the latest news, go to **latimes.com**.

SpaceX site on path to cityhood

Voters endorse incorporation for Musk's Texas launch area, known as Starbase. **NATION, A10**

Printed with soy inks on partially recycled paper.



Every story. Every section. Every feature. Subscribers get unlimited app access. Download now.

